

Burners — Examples of Play

Mechanics-only run-throughs of the engine (Fuel pools, Defend, soak-on-the-way-in, Hits on monster piles). No narration — just procedure, rolls, and the gauge. See [[Burners Adventure Game]] and [[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed (preferred Referee mode)]].

Example 1 — The Rat-Cellars (a crawl)

Job: clear the Rat-Cellars under Varn's granary; recover the strongbox. **Base Heat 6** (working ground). Torches burn 6 Turns. Wandering monsters per [[Burners Referee Guide#Turn Tracker]]: always 1-in-6; roll on even turns, and again when noise, dark, or wounds fire.

Crew (all character level 1 — one Approach point, four Traits, HP = 1d6 rolled):

Burner	Approach	HP	Held	Fuel on the Initiative roll
Kragg	Sword 1 (Veteran)	4	war-axe (3 slots, 2-handed, enchanted), gambeson (AC 2)	4 empty + 3 axe + 1 level = 8
Sefa	Craft 1 (Journeyman)	3	leather (AC 1); silvered knife (1 slot) once looted	4 empty + 1 knife + 1 level = 6
Brand	Heart 1 (Boss)	5	sword (2), leather (AC 1)	4 empty + 2 sword + 1 level = 7
Ilsa	Sorcerie 1 (Sorcerer)	3	spear (3 physical); 5 Arcana (hand size 5 — <i>Adhere</i> ready among them); wand drip (1 Arcana); leather (AC 1, 2 physical)	2 empty + 1 wand + 3 spear + 1 level = 7

Reminder — out of combat: 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Hostile magic: Fuel Defend vs cast total (see [[Burners Principles#Granular defense, not binary save]]).

Exploration

Turn 1 — Entry stair. x

- Sefa scouts (Craft): Pay @ Heat 6 → 2d6+1 = **8** ✓. Clear, no cost.
- Torch 1/6.

Turn 2 — Cellar 1, flooded. A slick beam (balance — Defend, Craft). x !

- Cross, 2d6 + Craft vs Heat 6 each:
 - Kragg 2d6 = **7** ✓ · Sefa 2d6+1 = **9** ✓ · Ilsa 2d6 = **10** ✓ · Brand 2d6 = **5**, short → slips, splash and noise → **Heat 7**. Log !.
- Immediate WM (noise): d6 = **4**. Nothing.

Turn 3 — Stuck door (heavy, swollen — a hard feat, Sword vs 9). x !

- Kragg heaves: $2d6+1 = 8$, short → holds, time burns.
- Second try: $2d6+1 = 10$ ✓ — it grinds open. Log !.
- Immediate WM (noise): $d6 = 5$. Nothing.
- Torch 3/6.

Turn 4 — Cellar 2. Covered pit (trap: flat Damage 2, no roll — detect or eat). x → fight !!

- Sefa checks for traps (Craft): Pay @ 7 → $2d6+1 = 6$, short 1 → **Heat 8**. Pit *not* spotted.
- Marching order puts Brand on it. It springs, no telegraph, no Fuel up out of combat: Damage 2 – Brand's AC 1 (soaks on the way in) = **1 to HP**. Brand 5 → 4.
- Even-turn WM (time): $d6 = 1$ — encounter. Cellar denizens, hostile by writ: **4 grave-rats** (HD 1 each → **2 red** apiece; bite quote **3**). Log !! for the fight; that is the encounter already — no noise roll on top of it. After the scrap, nobody Wounded → no wounds roll.

Combat 1 — Grave-rats (4). Heat 8

Rolling Initiative. Crew roll their Fuel (above); Initiative = count of 3s and 4s. Grave-rats are one knot: **group 1d6 = 2**. Four free bite quotes (one per rat in reach). Kragg reads **4** and acts first.

Round 1.

- **Kragg** attacks: burns a 5 → damage **5** → Hits $\lceil 5 \div 5 \rceil = 1$. All-red rat: pluck 1 red → **1 face-up left**. He burns a 6 to strike a **Spark**, Fuels it with a 2 for a second attack → damage **2** → **1 Hit** → pile gone. Rat 1 dead.
- **Brand** attacks: burns a 5 → **1 Hit** → rat 2 at **1 red**.
- **Ilsa** (spear) attacks: burns a 4 → **1 Hit** → finishes rat 2.
- **Rats** act: rats 3 and 4 bite Sefa (quote **3** each). She Defends the first 3 with a 4. Against the second 3, leather soaks 1 first; she burns a 3 to cut the rest. Zeroed.

Round 2.

- **Kragg** drops rat 3 with two blows (same math). **Brand** chips rat 4; **Ilsa** finishes it. Threat overcome → **vent 2** → **Heat 6**.

Note: each HD 1 rat is a 2-red pile — one solid Hit each, often two scrap blows. A swarm's teeth are its count of quotes, not any one blow — and a Burner's armor soaks each blow separately, so numbers grind rather than spike.

Turn 5 — rest of Cellar 2. x

- Loot niche: 120 gp, a **silvered knife** (1 slot). Sefa takes the knife.
- Torch 5/6; fresh torch lit.

Turn 6 — Cellar 3, the strongroom door. Masterwork lock (thief skill vs difficulty 10). x

- Sefa (Craft, tools): Deal → $2d6+1 = 9$. Holds; time cost → **Heat 7**.
- Sefa again: $2d6+1 = 12$ ✓. Open. Quiet work — no bang.
- Even-turn WM (time): $d6 = 6$. Nothing. (!! already spent its noise roll on the fight turn.)

Combat 2 — The Cellarer (a wight). Heat 7 → 9

Buried armed: **grave-sword** (quote **3**) and a **grave-byrnies** (old chain — loot for a Burner). HD 3 → stack **6**: paint **4 face-down** / **2 face-up** (mail + grave-cold flesh as shell). Silver is the **right tool** vs that closed shell. The Referee announces it rising from its bier: **+2 Heat** → **9**.

Rolling Initiative. Crew roll Fuel; the Cellarer rolls **group 1d6 = 5** and goes first. Two free sword quotes a round.

Round 1.

- **Wight**, two quotes — Referee **presses** the first (+6) onto Brand, second quote plain on Ilsa:
 - → **Brand**: pressed **3+6 = 9**. Leather soaks 1 → 8. He has not meleed → one die: burns a 5 → **3 to HP**. Brand 5 → **2**. (*Brand Fuel 7→6*.)
 - → **Ilsa**: quote **3**. Leather soaks 1 → 2. She burns a 4 → **0**. (*Fuel 7→6*.)
- **Kragg** attacks (Veteran, two blows; 2-handed axe → two dice a blow) — having meleed, he Defends without limit for the rest of this round:
 - Blow A: **6+5 = 11** damage. Closed: Hits $\lceil 11 \div 5 \rceil = 3$, -1 → **2 Hits** → pop **2 face-down**. Stack **2 down / 2 up**.
 - Blow B: **5+4 = 9**. Closed: $\lceil 9 \div 5 \rceil = 2$, -1 → **1 Hit** → **1 down / 2 up**.
- **Brand** attacks: sword **6**. Closed: $\lceil 6 \div 5 \rceil = 2$, -1 → **1 Hit** → **0 down / 2 up** — last face-down gone: **Cracked!**
- **Ilsa** casts *Adhere* (Thaumaturgy 1): burns 1 Fuel = **5** cast total; card **taps**. Control lane — no Hits. At speed the wight has no free Defend; the working sticks its sword-arm to the byrnie. (*Ilsa Fuel 6→5*.)
- **Sefa**, silvered knife — claims silver as the right tool, so her 1-slot knife burns an **extra die: 6 + 4 = 10** damage. Wight is Cracked — open: Hits $\lceil 10 \div 5 \rceil = 2$ → pop **2 face-up**. Pile gone. The Cellarer falls — silver and the extra die finished the meat; *Adhere* only took its arm out of the fight.

Threat overcome → **vent 2** → **Heat 7**.

Turn 7 — Strongbox.

- Carried out whole (2 slots; Kragg drops a torch bundle to fit it).
- Sefa checks for a second exit (Craft): Pay @ 7 → **2d6+1 = 11** ✓ — an old coal chute, out that way, skipping the flooded beam.

After

- **Downtime**: Heat cools to base; the job stayed quiet, so the town base is unchanged.
- **Take**: strongbox (Referee: 400 gp + deed papers), 120 gp, silvered knife, **the Cellarer's grave-sword** — old, fine make, a worn-off name (a Signature waiting to be read) — and its **grave-byrnie** (mail; Kragg claims it).
- **Hurts**: Brand at **2 HP** (no Wound — the press stung but did not drive past 0). Ilsa unhurt. Hour Rest refills Brand. Ilsa may spend a sleep-recovery card to untap *Adhere*.
- **Torches spent**: 2. **Turns**: 7.

Procedure Notes

- **Clocks**: 10-minute Turns on a visible Turn Tracker — count **1–6** then wrap (an hour); ! / !!, light notes, what they did. Checks leave no mark; even turns say when one is due. Always 1-in-6; roll on even turns, and again when noise, dark, or wounds fire. A full quiet cycle with food and water is Hour Rest (HP, if unwounded) — not a required rest tax. Magic out of combat is noise. See [\[\[Burners Referee Guide#Turn Tracker\]\]](#).
- **One roll out of combat**: 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Traps — see [\[\[Burners Principles#Pools, not fixed numbers\]\]](#).
- **Fuel is rolled on each Roll Initiative** — full pool on round 1; from round 2 on, refill one Fuel die per character level and roll those in. PC Initiative = count of 3s and 4s. Enemy groups: **1d6** each round (not Heat, not HD + weapon). Round 1 surprise: monsters first or last, no d6.
- **Damage you announce; the Referee converts**. Hits = $\lceil \text{damage} \div 5 \rceil$; closed → -1, always (armor is one card of soak). Claim the **right tool** to burn one extra Fuel into the blow (its face adds to damage). Face-down first, then face-up. **Cracked!** = last face-down gone (signal; the -1 ends). Dead = pile gone. See [\[\[Burners Referee Guide#Monsters at speed \(preferred Referee mode\)\]\]](#).

- **Defense (Burners):** melee 1 die (no limit once you have meleed this round); missile 1 die (2 with Cover); magic no limit. **Block / Cover** as in Combat. Monsters at speed have **no free Defend**.
- **The Wound model:** see [[Burners Principles#HP is plot armor; past 0 it gets real]].
- **Casting is the same economy:** Ilsa's *Adhere* was one Action, one Fuel die for the **cast total**; the card **tapped**; control stuck the arm — no Hits. Sleep recovers up to Sorcerie Level cards.
- **Closed shell vs right tool:** mundane steel chipped face-down slowly — the -1 stood until the last face-down popped. Once Cracked, silver and its extra die finished the face-up meat. Sorcery solved the arm; steel and silver killed. **Sorcerers solve; fighters kill.**
- **Press:** the wight's first quote got a bump when it mattered — hot fiction, not a Heat Initiative pool.
- **Nobody died.** Clean job.

Example 2 — The Gulls’ Rest (a parley gone sharp)

The same crew, a week later, fencing the deed papers from the Rat-Cellars. This one starts as a social scene on Heart and turns into a fight mid-sentence — watch where the initiative roll lands.

Scene: a back table at the Gulls’ Rest, evening crowd. The buyer is **Marlow**, a dockside fixer, flanked by two **bravos** and a quiet man with rings — a **sharper** (Sorcerer, Illusione). **Base Heat 4** (a quiet meet, but a crowded room and money on the table).

What’s in hand matters tonight. Nobody walks into a parley holding a war-axe. Kragg’s axe rides his back, Brand’s sword is at his hip, Sefa’s silvered knife is a holdout in her boot. Held slots only count on the Initiative roll if the thing is *in hand* when steel comes out.

The parley (Heart)

- **First meeting — Reaction roll** (Referee): $2d6 + \text{Brand's Heart } 1 = 8$. Cool but willing: Marlow will deal, at his price.
- **Brand opens** — the papers for 300 gp. That is a fair ask backed by real goods, so it simply works as an offer on the table (Step 1); no roll for whether the world listens.
- **Marlow lowballs** — 100 gp, and a smile. Brand wants the fixer’s *real* ceiling — a read, and risky to press for: Pay @ Heat 4 $\rightarrow 2d6+1 = 9$ ✓. The Referee gives it: Marlow is fronting for Varn’s rival and will pay well over 300 — but he wants the crew *cheap or gone*.
- **Brand presses** — names the rival aloud, and asks 400. A hard squeeze on a made man: Pay @ Heat 4 $\rightarrow 2d6+1 = 6$, short $\rightarrow$ the squeeze shows, the table hears it $\rightarrow$ **Heat 5**.
- **Sefa reads the room** (Craft): Deal @ 5 $\rightarrow 2d6+1 = 10$ ✓ — the bravos have shifted their stools clear of the table, and the ringed man’s hands are under it. A revealed threat sets a floor: **Heat holds at 5, floor 5**.
- **Marlow leans back** — “Three hundred, then. Shake on it.” The Referee telegraphs: the sharper’s lips are moving.

Steel comes out — roll initiative

The sharper casts a working at Brand. **A hostile spell is an attack: roll initiative.** He gains no free first strike for starting it — the whole room rolls with what it holds *right now*.

Side	Fuel pool	Initiative
Kragg (tankard, axe on back)	4 empty + 1 level = 5	3 (three 3s/4s)
Sefa (knife in boot — a holdout)	4 empty + 1 level = 5	1
Brand (sword at hip, not in hand)	4 empty + 1 level = 5	1
Ilsa (5 Arcana declared; wand drip 1; leather 2; no spear tonight)	4 empty + 1 wand + 1 level = 6	1

Side	Fuel pool	Initiative
Enemy group (sharper + bravos)	—	1d6 = 2
Sharper (HD 1 → 2 face-up ; Illusione hand; <i>Bewitch</i> ready)	free cast / quotes	—
Bravos (knives; HD 1 → 2 face-up each)	knife quote 2 each	—

Order: Kragg (3) → enemy group (2) → Brand, Sefa, Ilsa (1s; players choose among themselves). **Kragg acts before the man whose spell started the fight.**

Round 1.

- **Kragg** (Veteran, two attacks; the axe stays sheathed — this is a tavern) burns a held 6 to strike a **Spark**, then Fuels it with 5,4 to **Man-handle** — heaves the table into the sharper. Force 9; the Referee gives the sharper two free contest dice (4,2 = 6) → bowled over, **in the dirt**. The working is already in the air; it resolves on the enemy beat. Kragg spends one Veteran attack to **Block** for Brand. (*Kragg 5→2 dice; order stays locked.*)
- **Enemy group:**
 - **Sharper** (from the floor) finishes the cast — *Bewitch*: cast total **5**. The card taps. **Ilsa is adjacent and Wards**: Sorcerie 1, burns **1 Fuel** (a 4), cutting the cast to **1**. **Brand then Defends** with 1 die (a 3) → fully defended. No charm. (*Ilsa 6→5; Brand 5→4.*)
 - **Bravo 1** lunges at Sefa, knife quote **2** pressed (+2) → **4**. Sefa has not meleed → one die: burns a 3 → 1 through, no armor tonight → **Sefa 3 HP → 2**. (*Sefa 5→4.*)
 - **Bravo 2** hesitates — his partner is still up, the sharper is in the dirt. **Morale check (2d6 under Morale 7): 6 — holds**, barely. He circles.
- **Ilsa** (Ward was not her turn): casts *Adhere*. 1 die = **6** cast total (Spark). Card taps. At speed the sharper has no free Defend — hand sticks to the floorboards (effect lane, **no Hits**; stack still **2 face-up**). She Fuels the Spark: glue catches the other wrist too. (*Ilsa 5→3.*)
- **Brand** rises, sword *now* in hand (drawing comes free with his Action), and swings at bravo 1: 1 die = **5** → Hits $\lceil 5 \div 5 \rceil = 1$ (all face-up) → **1 face-up left**; second Veteran attack burns a **4** → **1 Hit** → pile gone. (*Brand 5→3.*)
- **Sefa** draws the holdout — **1 Fuel to pull it in a fight** — and marks bravo 2. (*Sefa 4→3.*)

Round 2. Roll Initiative: refill +1 die each, recount 3s/4s; enemy group rolls **1d6** again. Kragg still tops it.

- **Kragg's** refill is a 6. He burns it to strike a **Spark**, then Fuels it with 4,3 to haul the sharper up by the collar — a **Man-handle** to grapple, force 7 against a man in the dirt, pinned; the Referee rules there is no real contest. Held fast. (*Kragg 3→0.*)
- **Sharper**, ringless and in a fist: folds. “Enough — *enough.*”
- **Bravo 2** — his principal just quit: **Morale check: 10 — breaks**, and he's out the door.
- Fight over. It never rose past the floor: **Heat 5**, and the room saw the *other* table start it.

After

- **The deal:** Marlow, dusting off his coat, pays **350 gp** for the papers — the crew's read was true, and the botched charm shamed his table, which is worth 50 gp of face. Money changes hands over a righted table.
- **The take:** 350 gp, one confiscated **ring** (Wizard Drip find; no bonus cards), and a bravo's knife in the floorboards.
- **Hurts:** Sefa 2/3 HP — an hour's rest with food refills her. Nobody wounded, nobody dead, nothing burned. In a tavern that is a masterpiece of restraint.
- **Heat:** cools to the town base at downtime. The Gulls' Rest will serve them again. Marlow will not forget.

Procedure Notes

- **Social scenes:** see [[Burners Principles#Two engines]] and [[Burners Principles#Heat is scene pressure]]. Heart pays for risky reads and squeezes as Pay rolls.
- **Heat is the social gauge too.** The meet opened at 4, climbed on a botched press, and a revealed threat set a floor. When steel came out, enemy **Initiative** was a **group 1d6**, not Heat.
- **Declaring an attack is “roll initiative” — and the declarer is not first.** The sharper’s charm started the fight and Kragg still beat him to the floor. A hostile working where no fight is underway triggers initiative like a drawn blade; nobody gets a free strike for moving first in the fiction (no surprise here — both sides knew steel was coming).
- **You fight with what’s in hand.** Tavern pools are thin: sheathed swords and slung axes throw no dice on the Fuel roll. Ilsa’s **wand drip** and empty pack carried her share — empty Arcana add nothing. Brand’s draw came free with his Action; Sefa’s holdout cost the 1 Fuel a holdout costs.
- **Ward, shown:** Ilsa cuts the cast with $\leq$ Sorcerie Level Fuel; Brand then Defends the remainder. Control never lands partially on a clean stop.
- **Control lands as an effect, not HP:** see [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]]. Had the charm landed, Brand loses no HP — the crew attacks the reason (concentration, hand, skin).
- **Morale as written (2d6 vs the score):** the bravos were never going to die for Marlow’s face. One blow and one bad round asked the question twice, and the second answer was the door.